35 INT. SURESH'S HOUSE - DAY 35

A small, very neat concrete house. A polished red floor. Plastic flowers. On the wall, in a gilt frame, a photograph of the Little Flower on her launch day, men crowded on her deck with garlands. In the middle of them a younger Varghese, laughing.

Anjali sets a small digital recorder and a pair of closed headphones on the dining table. Suresh stands across the table from her.

ANJALI
It's eleven minutes. His voice comes in at four. I took a little of the hiss down. I didn't cut anything.

SURESH
Why not?

ANJALI
It isn't mine to cut.

She goes out. The door closes behind her.

Suresh stands for a while. Then he sits, puts on the headphones and presses play.

Very faint, leaking from the earcups:

VARGHESE (V.O.)
(through the headphones)
Little Flower copies. I'll take them in. I'll light the boats.

POV ANJALI, THROUGH THE WINDOW FROM THE FRONT STEP: SURESH AT THE TABLE IN THE HEADPHONES, VERY STILL. SLOWLY HE PUTS ONE HAND FLAT ON THE TABLE AND LEAVES IT THERE.

BACK TO SCENE.

The recording ends. Suresh takes the headphones off and lays them down very gently. He goes to the photograph and straightens it, though it was already straight.

He opens the front door. Anjali sits on the step with her back to him.

SURESH
He sounds young.

ANJALI
He was younger than you are now.

SURESH
(a beat)
He said, I'm going back. He knew.

ANJALI
They both knew.

SURESH
Come inside. I'll make tea. I make terrible tea.

She gets up and goes in.

36 INT. PORT TRUST OFFICE - DAY 36

The same fans. Krishnadas at his desk. Suresh sits in the chair where Anjali sat.

PORT OFFICER
Mr. Pillai, your own company booked the excavator. The container yard contractor starts piling on the twentieth. If I move your date, I am explaining to Ernakulam why.

SURESH
One week.

PORT OFFICER
Not one day.

SURESH
There is a station log that says the Port ordered that transmitter shut down at 23:40 on the fourteenth of November 1999. In a cyclone. With eleven boats out.

Krishnadas stops writing and looks up properly for the first time.

PORT OFFICER
(carefully)
If there is such a document, there will be an inquiry. Inquiries take nine years. The building comes down tomorrow either way.

SURESH
I understand.
(he slides a typed sheet across)
Then sign this. The site generator, the truck and two of my men, tonight, on the beach below the station. One night.

PORT OFFICER
For what?

SURESH
A listening.

Krishnadas signs the sheet without reading it and stamps it.

PORT OFFICER
(handing it back)
My father was on the Jyothi. He came home.

37 EXT. KADALKKARA BEACH - DUSK 37

The sun going down red into the sea. Fishing boats pulled up in a long row. Kids on bamboo ladders string paper lanterns and kerosene lanterns between the masts, a line of small lights the length of the beach.

Fathima at a trestle table with her copper urn and a stack of steel tumblers. Rahul and Meenu run cable from the Nagra to two big loudspeakers on bamboo stands, borrowed from the church festival.

The contractor's generator truck grinds onto the sand, two of Suresh's crew pushing at the tailboard. Suresh walks backward in front of it, guiding it in.

SURESH
Left. Stop. Chock it.

RAHUL
How much power is that?

SURESH
Enough for this beach and half the village.

RAHUL
We need about forty watts.

SURESH
Then you'll have a lot left over.

Fathima holds out a tumbler of tea to Suresh. It is the first thing she has ever handed him.

FATHIMA
You came.

SURESH
I brought the lights.

FATHIMA
That's what I said.

At the far end of the beach, where the lanterns stop, a man in a clean shirt stands alone with his hands in his pockets. Joe. He walked here. He comes no closer.

Fathima looks at him a long moment. Then she pours a second tumbler and sends Meenu down the beach with it. Joe takes it.

JOE
(to Meenu)
Thank her for me.

38 INT. THOMAS HOUSE - APPACHAN'S ROOM - DUSK 38

Anjali buttons Appachan's good white shirt, from the top, the right way. He is thinner since the hospital. The keys hang on their nail by the door.

APPACHAN
Is she on tonight?
(beat)
മറിയാമ്മ. Is she on shift?

Anjali's fingers stop on a button.

ANJALI
(a breath)
ഉവ്വ്, അപ്പച്ചാ. She's on tonight. It's her last shift. We're all going down to the beach to listen to her.

APPACHAN
The sea?

ANJALI
Calm.

APPACHAN
She'll be embarrassed.

ANJALI
(smiling)
She'll laugh.

APPACHAN
She always laughs.

He stands. Kannan gets up off the floor too. Appachan takes the keys from the nail and hangs them round his neck. He stands with them a moment. Then he lifts them off and hangs them back on the nail.

APPACHAN (CONT'D)
Leave them. We won't need them tonight.

39 EXT. KADALKKARA BEACH - NIGHT 39

Rain has stopped. The generator truck hums behind the dunes. Three hundred people sit on the wet sand facing two speaker stacks.

AERIAL: THE BEACH IN THE DARK. A LONG CURVE OF LANTERNS STRUNG BETWEEN THE BOATS, THREE HUNDRED PEOPLE ON THE SAND FACING THE SEA, AND ABOVE THEM ON THE DUNE THE DEAD MAST.

The generator hums behind the boats. The two loudspeakers stand at the waterline facing inland, their backs to the sea. Families on mats. Children asleep on laps. The church choir sits together, not singing. Latha, in uniform, stands at the back by her jeep.

Appachan sits in a plastic chair in the front row, Kannan at his feet. Anjali on the sand beside him. Rahul and Meenu at the Nagra, headphones on.

Anjali stands. The beach goes quiet.

ANJALI
My mother's name was Mariamma Thomas. Most of you knew her better than I did. I was eleven.
(beat)
This is the station's log tape from the fourteenth of November 1999. It runs fifty minutes. I haven't cut anything out.
(to Rahul)
Play it.

Over the speakers, huge: hiss. Rain on a roof twenty-three years ago. Then Mariamma's laugh.

MARIAMMA (V.O.)
(over the speakers)
No, Joe, I'm not going to say it like that, they'll think somebody died...

Some of the old women laugh, they can't help it, and cover their mouths with the ends of their saris.

The tape runs. The tide creeps up the sand. Nobody leaves. On the tape, a heavy clunk, then a silence so complete that a child starts to cry and is hushed. Then, very small:

MARIAMMA (V.O.)
Little Flower, Little Flower, this is Kadalkkara, on battery.

VARGHESE (V.O.)
Kadalkkara, Little Flower. Weak, but I have you. Go.

In the front rows an old skipper stands up without meaning to. Then another.

Suresh stands and walks down to the speakers. At a nod from Anjali, Rahul brings the tape down low under him. It keeps running.

SURESH
Eleven boats went out that night.
(beat)
Little Flower. Seagull. Morning Star. Bismillah. Sea Queen. Ambadi. Jyothi. Mother Mary. St. Antony. Kairali. Pournami.

With each name, somewhere in the crowd, somebody stands. An old man. A widow. A boy in his grandfather's place.

SURESH (CONT'D)
Eight came home. They came home on my father's light. My father had it from Mariamma Thomas, who sat in the dark and talked to him on a battery after the Port switched her off.
(he looks at Anjali)
For twenty-three years we said the wrong thing about her. I said it loudest.

Rahul brings the tape back up.

VARGHESE (V.O.)
I'm going back for Hamza. Mariamma, I'm going back.

By her urn, Fathima closes her eyes.

At the edge of the lantern light Joe stands where he has stood for an hour, on the point of leaving. Latha comes and stands beside him.

LATHA
(low)
Stay to the end.

JOE
(low)
I was here for the end once before. I left.

LATHA
So stay this time.

He stays.

MARIAMMA (V.O.)
Kadalkkara. Battery's going. Time is twenty-three fifty-one. Anjali's asleep.

Appachan turns his head toward the speakers, as if someone had called him from the next room.

APPACHAN
(clearly, to no one)
There she is.

Anjali takes his hand.

MARIAMMA (V.O.)
I'll put the lantern on the jetty for you, Varghese. Look for the lantern.

The long hiss.

APPACHAN
(softly)
Good girl. Go on now. Go home.

He is smiling. His eyes are wet. He is at peace.

Fathima crouches beside Anjali.

FATHIMA
Rahul's on the roof. He says it's ready.

Anjali looks up at the dark station on the dune. A torch blinks twice on the roof.

40 EXT. COAST RADIO STATION - ROOF - NIGHT 40

A flat concrete roof, weeds in the cracks, the mast rising from one corner. Below: the lanterns, the people, the hum of the generator.

Rahul kneels by the biscuit-tin transmitter on an upturned fish crate. A heavy cable runs from it to the base of the mast on crocodile clips. A car battery beside it. The Nagra, carried up in its suitcase, lies open next to the tin, the reel rewound.

Anjali climbs up through the roof hatch.

RAHUL
I've matched it to the mast. It'll go ten kilometres. Fifteen if God's listening.

ANJALI
It's not legal.

RAHUL
It's not legal for one night.

He hands her the microphone: the Walkman microphone, taped to the handle of a wooden spoon.

ANJALI
What frequency?

RAHUL
Hers. The one inside the front cover of the log.

She looks out at the sea, black, the lights of a few far boats on it.

ANJALI
I've never done this.

RAHUL
You do it every day. You just take it out afterwards.

She keys the microphone.

ANJALI
(into the microphone)
All stations, all stations, this is Kadalkkara.
(her voice shakes; she lets it)
Kadalkkara coast radio, for the last time from this mast. Wind northwest, ten knots. Swell under a metre. Low tide at five fourteen.
(a breath)
What follows is a recording from the night of the fourteenth of November 1999. The operator is Mariamma Thomas.

She nods. Rahul pushes the lever. The reels turn, the lamp on the tin glows, and Mariamma's voice goes out through the old mast into the dark.

They sit with their backs against the parapet. Below them, the beach. Ahead, the sea, listening.

WIDE ON THE STATION FROM THE SEA: THE SMALL LIGHT ON THE ROOF, THE MAST, THE LANTERNS ALONG THE BEACH, ALL OF IT TINY UNDER THE STARS.

DISSOLVE TO:

41 EXT. COAST RADIO STATION - DAY 41

Morning. Hard sun. A hundred people behind the tape, quieter than a crowd should be. Police barricades. Latha's jeep on the track.

A yellow tracked excavator with a demolition grab crawls up the sand track. Suresh, in a hard hat and a high-visibility vest, walks round it once and signals his crew to clear the area.

Anjali stands at the tape with Appachan, in his good shirt again. Fathima on his other side. Kannan at their feet.

APPACHAN
What are they doing?

ANJALI
Taking it down.

APPACHAN
Is everyone home?

ANJALI
Everyone's home.

Suresh looks across. Anjali nods. He lifts his hand to the operator.

The arm rises, swings and bites into the first wall. Concrete groans and gives. Dust rolls out over the crowd. Fathima flinches. Appachan does not.

By noon the operations room is a hill of broken concrete. The grab works at the mast footings. The steel shrieks. The mast leans, slowly, and seems to stop, as if thinking about it.

WIDE ON THE MAST AS IT LEANS PAST THE POINT OF NO RETURN AND FALLS INTO THE COCONUT GROVE. PALM FRONDS BURST. CROWS GO UP IN A BLACK SHEET.

The ground shakes. Dust drifts over everything.

In the silence, Appachan claps his hands. Once. The sharp clap the men on the beach give when a boat comes in over the bar.

An old fisherman claps once too. Then a few more. Not applause. The clap for a boat coming in.

Suresh takes off his hard hat and walks over to the tape. He and Anjali stand on either side of it.

SURESH
That's it, then.

ANJALI
That's the building.

FATHIMA
(holding out a tumbler of tea to Suresh)
Drink. You look like a ghost.

CUT TO:

42 INT. FATHIMA'S TEA SHOP - DAY 42

The afternoon lull. Newspapers spread on the floor. Rahul kneels on them, painting white letters onto a long jackwood plank. Meenu outlines each one in blue. So far the plank says Low Tide Rad.

On the counter the biscuit-tin transmitter, scorched black down one side, has a cardboard sign in Meenu's writing: Do not touch. Historic.

Anjali sits at the corner table with her phone. Fathima wipes the same patch of counter for a long time.

STUDIO PRODUCER (ON PHONE)
I've held the detergent people a week, Anjali. They redid the voice. She sounds tired again. I need you back Monday.

ANJALI
I'm not coming back, Nikhil. I'll send notes on the open sessions. Tell the client she sounds tired because she's a person.

STUDIO PRODUCER (ON PHONE)
Is this about money? Because I can...

ANJALI
It's about breathing.
(beat)
Leave the breaths in. That's my last note.

She hangs up and puts the phone face down. Fathima keeps wiping.

ANJALI (CONT'D)
You can stop pretending you weren't listening.

FATHIMA
I wasn't listening. I'm cleaning.

ANJALI
That spot's very clean.

FATHIMA
It's a very dirty spot.
(beat)
So you're staying.

ANJALI
Somebody has to stop him setting the shop on fire.

RAHUL
(not looking up)
Once. Small fire.

Fathima puts the cloth down, comes round the counter, sits across from Anjali and says nothing at all, which for Fathima is a speech.

Rahul paints the last letter and sits back on his heels.

RAHUL (CONT'D)
Low Tide Radio.

MEENU
(critically)
The O is fat.

RAHUL
The O is perfect.

43 EXT. KADALKKARA HARBOUR - DAWN 43

Blue light. Engines cough and catch one after another down the wharf. Diesel smoke on the water. Men throw lines and jump aboard.

In every wheelhouse, a radio. Cheap transistors on shelves. A marine set on the Bismillah. A transistor hung from a nail on the Jyothi. From all of them at once, a little out of step, the same voice.

ANJALI (ON RADIO)
Good morning, Kadalkkara. This is Low Tide Radio with the weather for the boats. Wind east-northeast, eight knots, backing north by afternoon. Swell one metre. Visibility good.

On the Jyothi the Old Fisherman stops coiling a rope and turns the transistor up.

ANJALI (ON RADIO) (CONT'D)
Low tide at five forty...
(a rustle of paper)
No. Five fifty-two. Sorry, Raghavan. Don't come and shout at me.

The Old Fisherman laughs out loud, alone on his deck. On the radio Anjali laughs too. She lets it run. Nobody cuts it.

ANJALI (ON RADIO) (CONT'D)
(still laughing)
Go well. Come home.

The boats go out through the harbour mouth in a line, past the breakwater, into the light.

44 EXT. KADALKKARA BEACH - DAY 44

Low tide. The sea has gone out a very long way. The wet sand shines like a mirror with the sky in it.

Anjali and Appachan walk along the water's edge, slowly, his arm through hers. Kannan runs ahead through the shallow pools, scattering crabs, runs back, runs ahead again.

Behind them, on the dune where the station stood, there is only sky, a heap of broken concrete and a stump of steel.

Anjali stops and looks at the watch on her wrist. 23:52. She pulls out the crown and winds it, turn after turn, then sets the hands to the morning. The second hand starts to move.

When she takes his arm again, Appachan hums. Four notes, wobbling. The station jingle from the cassette.

She hums it back.

They walk on. Behind them, their footprints fill with water.

FADE OUT.